

## US AI job fears are outpacing actual job losses

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### 【メール原文】

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The AI jobs backlash is arriving before broad job losses

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Generative AI has not displaced American workers in aggregate, and significant workforce displacement is unlikely before 2028.

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Labor market adjustment is running through hiring rather than firing, but over time the squeeze could spread to mid-tier roles where value is output rather than judgment.

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The political backlash is already running ahead of the evidence and will shape regulation regardless of the labor market outcome.

More than three years into enterprise adoption, AI shows no sign of substantially displacing American workers. That is enough for a preliminary call that significant workforce displacement is unlikely before 2028, barring a recession or a step change in AI reliability. Workers in highly exposed occupations—such as customer service representatives, computer programmers, and technical writers—have not fared worse in aggregate. However, hiring and separations are both subdued—stricter immigration policies reduce the flow of new workers, which may be masking what AI is doing to hiring flows. And early-career employment is likely declining in exposed occupations, although the research is inconclusive.

Much of the job loss commonly attributed to AI is corporate storytelling. Through July 2026, US-based employers cited AI in 112,713 announced job cuts—about 24% of announced cuts—but these figures record what firms say, not verified causes. AI lets firms convert bad news into an innovation story, which investors rewarded for a time. Separate surveys from the Federal Reserve Bank of New York indicate that regional employers are primarily adjusting their workforce via retraining, with layoffs reported at only 4% of AI-using service sector firms.

Productivity gains from AI are uneven so far. In experiments, inexperienced workers improve markedly in speed and quality, while experienced workers often see smaller gains. That does not preclude a slowdown in junior hiring, as AI can complement the juniors a firm keeps while substituting for juniors it otherwise would have hired. AI also lets skilled people take on more complex work at lower cost, while expertise still directs it, though the data shows some negative impact on quality of output for skilled

work. Workplace adoption is broad but shallow. According to a survey of 40,000 respondents, about 45% of employed adults use generative AI at work, but it touches only about 6% of work hours and saves about 2%.

AI typically boosts speed or quality for initial work, rather than final output, creating bottlenecks. The National Bureau of Economic Research found that developers using autonomous coding agents increased coding output by 180% but shipped only about 30% more releases. Output volume—code—expands wherever a task is automated, then bottlenecks when an experienced human must review, integrate, test, or release it. Because plausible AI output can be wrong, more first-pass output can increase review burdens rather than immediately delivering value. As long as humans must direct, integrate, and check AI output, gains per worker can arrive without large staff cuts.

AI-inspired job losses could fall on mid-tier throughput roles as well. Mid-tier roles—first-pass analysis, financial models, and document review—derive their value from supervised execution, and become vulnerable if AI can complete whole workflows with little expert review. While evidence for this is currently thin in the data, over two to five years, firms could adjust through attrition, fewer promotions, redesigned roles, and selective layoffs, eventually thinning the senior pipeline.

Pessimism among Americans is running ahead of the evidence. Four in five Americans expect AI to reduce jobs over the next decade, according to Gallup . In a separate survey , respondents put their average probability of losing their own job to AI within two years at 20%. The disconnect likely has several sources: AI firms market the technology as labor-replacing; the job market is hard in some industries even where AI is not to blame; and US politicians and media are both reacting to and fueling AI pessimism. The US backlash is sharper than in other AI-skeptical markets, partly because Americans have less confidence a safety net will protect them. In the EU, comparable skepticism is absorbed by the EU's regulatory responses rather than populist mobilization (see: ChatGPT designation extends platform regulation to AI chatbots , 04 Sept 2026).

Politicians will keep acting on AI job-loss fears whether or not the data bear them out. Proposed disclosure rules measure what firms say, not what they do (see: Four regulatory camps emerge as states move toward restricting data centers , 30 July 2026). Even if AI continues to have a limited effect on the labor market, negative public views on AI's effects will be a major factor in driving a negative political cycle for AI developers. The dominant AI narrative—centered on job replacement and rapid technological expansion—runs counter to the populist baseline of both parties; calls for nationwide moratoriums from incoming House Energy and Commerce Committee Chair Frank Pallone (D-NJ) and Texas Governor Greg Abbott reflect a rare cross-partisan alignment. Politicians making a populist case against data centers can be expected to also take action to protect workers in some fields from AI-related displacement (see: Mounting techlash imperils sector's political and policy gains , 21 May 2026).

The biggest near-term risk is cyclical rather than technological. Research on past automation finds that most declines in routine employment clustered around recessions. A downturn would let firms do openly through job cuts what they now might do through attrition. It would also make a disputed labor-market signal more politically salient, as Americans are likely to blame job losses from a recession partly on AI even if not caused by it. Our benign basecase therefore depends on both shallow deployment and a stable macro environment.

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